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## Mauryan Taxila

TAXILA IS THE NAME OF AN ANCIENT CITY AS WELL as the sobriquet of an archaeological site. When Taxila figures in the ambitions of eastern aggrandizers like the Maurya rulers based in Pataliputra, or in those of invaders from the West—the Persian Darius I and Alexander of Macedon, mainly—it is a single city that comes to mind. Its Sanskrit name, Takshashila, was first pared down to Taxila by the Greeks when they described it as the foremost city of Punjab, and presumably since the Greek version trips easier off the tongue than the Sanskrit—unlike the slightly absurd-sounding anglicization 'Sandrakottos' for Chandragupta—the abbreviation took root and was extended to describe the larger archaeological site of Taxila. The latter is actually an ensemble of several sites: three city sites, and the ruins of many Buddhist stupas and monasteries scattered across hills and spurs in the surrounding countryside, including knolls near the Tamra nala and the northern slopes of the ridges of Margala. Of these, it is the settlement of people that came to occupy what is known as the Bhir mound which is central to this story, since it was at the Mauryan city there that Ashoka is said to have arrived at the behest of his father.

No chronicle or record contemporaneous with Ashoka exists to tell us of his campaign to pacify Taxila. It is once again the second CE *Ashokavadana* which recounts his arrival there, as also the circumstances which drove him so far to the north-west frontiers of the kingdom. Taxila, the text tells us, was in the midst of a rebellion which Bindusara wanted his son to quell—bizarrely, says its translator John Strong, without weapons: